

believe there's such a thing as "absolute poverty"—having less than is necessary to live a proper life. A UN declaration lists the minimum basic human needs as food, clean water, sanitation, health care, shelter, education, and information. The declaration defines absolute poverty as being deprived of some or all of these necessities of life.

Another way of defining poverty is by measuring income. The World Bank, for instance, has suggested an international "poverty line," set at around \$2 per day. Anyone earning below that level of income can be described as living in poverty. But because the cost of living can vary greatly from country to country, this definition doesn't accurately indicate all levels of poverty. Perhaps a better way would be to measure not what people have, but what they don't have—the things that they're deprived of.